

mature look of the Compaq X1237AP. The Samsung X10 nearly won the top honours in this category, and deserves a worthy mention. This notebook is a great product, especially if you are looking for a light-weight solution that fits your image. Other products that deserve a mention are the Samsung P30, X05 and LG LM 40, which offers the best battery life of them all.

DESKTOP REPLACEMENTS

Notebooks that perform as well as a desktop, and are also mobile, fall in the Desktop replacement category. Their mobility is limited due to their bulk and weight.

However, workhorse notebooks are getting better, and the line that separates these two categories is getting thinner. Hence, many vendors have stopped offering them as a performance alternative. This was evident from the fact that the category has only three products.

Two notebooks from ACi—the Emerald M10 and the Ultima—and a Dell Latitude D800 formed this category.

Features

Both the ACi notebooks were powered by desktop processors from Intel. The Dell Latitude D800 had the latest 2 GHz Pentium M processor with 2 MB of L2 cache as against the 512 KB found on the other two.

The D800 offers 1 GB of main memory, while both the ACi models have a relatively modest 512 MB of main memory—enough for most system-intensive applications.

With a 17-inch display, the ACi Ultima is way ahead of both the notebooks in terms of viewable real-estate offered. The Dell D800 makes up for the smaller 15.4-inch display by providing a higher resolution screen that is both crisp and brilliant. The ACi Emerald M10 just has a standard 15-inch screen—no match for the other two.

USB ports were in abundance, legacy ports such as Serial and parallel were also present, and all had Firewire ports. The usual Ethernet, modem and Infrared ports are also standard. The Dell D800 has a Bluetooth adapter. The Emerald M10 has a memory card reader that can read all six available types of cards.

Both the ACi models come with 40 GB of hard disk space—too little for a desktop replacement. The Dell offers 80 GB of space. nVidia's GeForceGo FX-5650 powers Dell Latitude D800, whereas the ACi offers an ATI Mobility Radeon 9600 on the M10 and a 9000 on the Ultima. The Dell offers a DVD-writer, while ACi offers just a combo drive and a vanilla CD-ROM drive on the M10 and Ultima respectively.



Securing Your Laptop

It's quite easy to buy the costliest and top-of-the-line laptop; protecting it from thefts is well, not that easy. Universal security slots are available on almost all available laptop models. These slots use a variety of locking devices, which keep your laptop attached to a solid base. Moreover, there are a number of other devices ranging from motion-sensing PCMCIA cards that set off alarms in the range of 110dB to biometric fingerprinting devices that secure your laptop and render it useless if no proper authentication is provided.

If your laptop contains critical data, use devices such as smart cards and automatic IR-access locking devices. These ensure that data stays where it ought to be.

Increasingly, many laptop manufacturers are paying special attention to security needs. Acer and Samsung, for instance, provide security options, which thwart any attempt to steal data.

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